11-1. Political Parties

Breakout Sessions

POLS 1101

8:40am-9:35am Baldwin 322

& 9:55am-10:50am Journalism 509

SIYUAN (Siri) ZHAO

Siri.Zhao@uga.edu

https://siyuanzhao-pa.github.io/

Exam Hand Back

- ***Add points wrong***
  - ***WITHIN TODAY (Friday) , or right after class***
- ***Questions on why I lost points in short-answers***
  - ***WITHIN TODAY (Friday), or right after class***
- ***Appeal your grade***
  - ***WITHIN 24 hours (Friday & Saturday)***
  - ***Do as told by the syllabus***
    - You must write a statement to have the assignment regraded saying why you believe you should have received more credit and you will need to give me your blue book.
    - If you appeal your grade, I (your TA) will need to regrade which could result in a higher grade, a lower grade, or no change at all.
    - Only submit an appeal if you are sure that you can make a strong case for a higher score!
    - If you are still unsatisfied with your grade after that, you can repeat the process with Professor Nicholson.

- **Starting from this week, we will focus on who are able to turn the "scattered" preferences into organized political power, and how (why) they achieve this goal.**
  - Political parties
  - Interest groups
  - Mass media
  - Citizens' political participation
    - Expressing (Public) Opinion
    - Responding to Campaigns
    - Voting in Elections

Political Parties & Interest Groups

- **Where is an interest group most likely to look party-like, and where is it least likely to replace a party?**

Dimension	Political Parties	Interest Groups
Definition	An organization that **sponsors candidates for political office** *under the organization's name*	Organized associations that seek to **influence public policy** without running candidates for office.
Core Functions	- Nominate candidates for public office - Organize election campaigns - Propose alternative government programs - Coordinate the actions of government officials	- Representation - Participation - Education (political socialization) - Agenda building - Program monitoring
Membership Base	Broad and diverse, representing wide social segments (e.g., multiple classes, regions, ideologies).	(Often) Narrow and specialized, often representing particular occupations, industries, or causes.

Political Parties & Interest Groups (cont`d)

Dimension	Political Parties	Interest Groups
Organizational Structure	Hierarchical, with national, state, and local branches; formal leadership and membership.	May be highly professionalized (e.g., trade associations) or loosely organized (e.g., grassroots movements).
Relationship to Government	More direct. Actively nominate and run candidates.	More indirect. Do not run candidates; may endorse or fund them indirectly.
Main Strategies	- Electoral competition - Coalition-building (in multi-party systems / parliamentary systems) - Legislative and executive action	- Lobbying - Campaign contributions (PACs/Super PACs) - Litigation - Grassroots mobilization - Media and public campaigns
Source of Legitimacy	Popular mandate through democratic elections.	Expertise, resources, and member support.
Role for Citizens	Provides choices in elections; connects voters to governing institutions.	Channels citizen interests into policy advocacy (often biased toward the benefits of the upper-class); gives voice to specific concerns.
Theoretical Foundation	Reflects **majoritarian democracy** and responsible party government.	Embodies **pluralist democracy**, where multiple organized interests compete for influence.

The American Two-Party System

- ***Why a two-party system in the U.S.?*** Why do parties operate in a different way under parliamentary systems (e.g., the U.K. or Canada)? **The electoral system!**
  - **Majority representation**: one office is won by the single candidate who collects the most votes (**simple plurality**, tending to produce two competing powers – consolidating as many people as possible)
  - **Proportional representation**: legislative seats are awarded to a party in proportion to the vote that party wins in an election. (tending to produce several parties; more supporters are preferred, but there may not exist a "sore loser".)

- **Is the two-party system still capable of representing the diversity in the U.S. nowadays?**

Term	Definition	Example	Common Use Cases
Relative Majority (Simple Plurality)	A candidate/option wins if it has **more votes than any other**, but **not necessarily more than half** of all votes.	Candidate A: 40 votes, Candidate B: 35, Candidate C: 25 → A wins with 40 (not >50%).	U.S. congressional elections, U.K. House of Commons elections (first-past-the-post).
Absolute Majority	A candidate/option must receive **more than half (>50%) of all votes cast** to win.	Total votes = 100 → a candidate needs at least 51 to achieve absolute majority.	Presidential elections in France (two-round system), parliamentary votes requiring >50%.

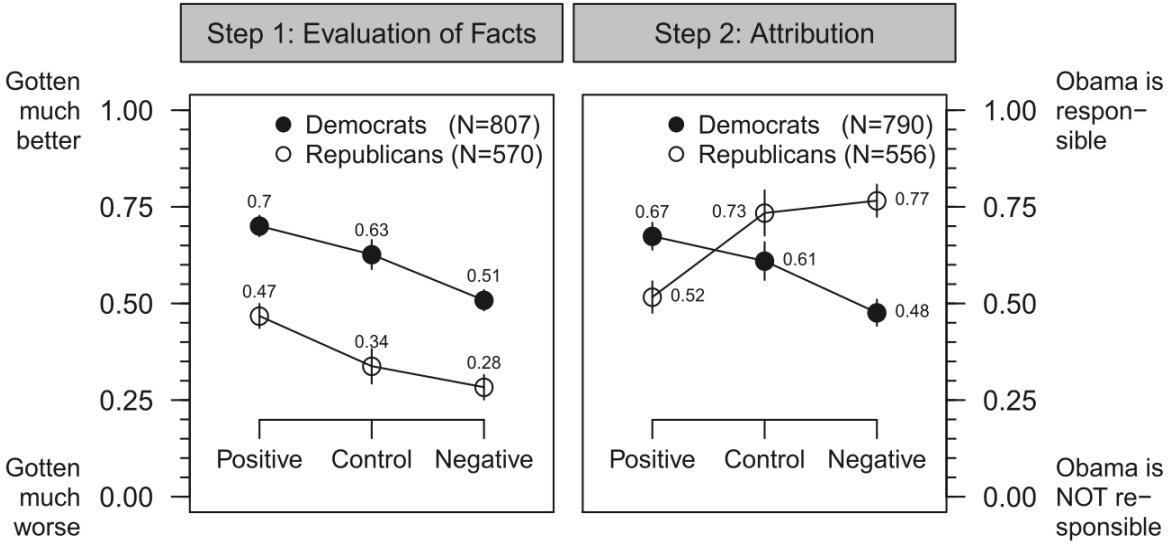
The American Two-Party System (cont`d)

- ***Why always the two parties?***
  - Shaped by the president election – as many votes as possible!
  - **The historical pattern of political socialization**
    - The two parties persist simply because they have persisted.
    - **Party identification**, shaped by income, education, religion, ethnicity, age, gender, region, parents…

- **How important is party identification?**
  - An example: **Bisgaard (2019) AJPS**

  - "The acknowledgement of new facts can lead citizens to reason about the question of responsibility in a highly partisan-motivated fashion."

FIGURE 2 Partisans Update Their Economic Perceptions in a Parallel Fashion, but Polarize in the Attribution of Responsibility (United States)



Party Organizations (for Review)

- **National Party Organizations**
  - **National convention**: nominate a presidential candidate; supreme governing body
  - **National committee**: RNC, DNC
    - They do NOT direct or control the crucial presidential campaigns.
  - **Congressional party conferences**: select party leaders; decide committee assignments (only within the Congress)
  - **Congressional campaign committee**
    - Despite the weakness of national party committees, both party organizations were strong in Congress.

- **State and Local Party Organizations**
  - American political parties are characterized by ***decentralization***, despite the **party machine** (a centralized organization that dominated local politics by controlling elections). The individual state and local party organizations vary widely in strength.

The Model of Responsible Party Government

- **Remember: Ideal Type!**
  - Parties should present clear and coherent programs to voters.
  - Voters should choose candidates on the basis of party programs.
  - The winning party should carry out its program once in office.
  - Voters should hold the governing party responsible at the next election for executing its program.

- **Discussion Questions**
  - In which aspects does the U.S. party system ***fail*** to meet the standards of responsible party government?
  - Would adopting a more responsible party model make American politics **more effective** or **more polarized**?

11-2. Interest Groups

Breakout Sessions

POLS 1101

8:40am-9:35am Baldwin 322

& 9:55am-10:50am Journalism 509

SIYUAN (Siri) ZHAO

Siri.Zhao@uga.edu

https://siyuanzhao-pa.github.io/

How do Interests Get Organized?

- **Awareness**
  - Growing awareness may result from an adverse change in circumstances or **changing definitions of a problem**. (Note: "constructed reality")
- **Leadership**
  - The leader is called "**interest group entrepreneur**".
- **Socio-economic status**
  - Upper-status groups are more likely to participate in politics. (Only **minimal resources** and **limited channels** to contact and recruit people from lower SES)
    - BUT it doesn't mean they can hardly be represented – **citizen groups** (lobbying organization built around policy concerns unrelated to members' vocational interests)
    - Can ordinary people rely on those "kind elites"?
  - Actually, most of them did… - **the free-rider problem** in collective actions!
    - **How to solve the free-rider problem? (See slides)**

      Selective benefits; solidary incentives; purposive incentives; mandatory membership; …

Actors of Interest Groups: Key Examples

- Members & Volunteers (non-membership)
- Lobbyists (full-time or part-time; experience, knowledge, and connections)
  - "Revolving door" between the government and the private sector

- **Political Action Committees (PAC) – the costs of free speech?**
  - Pooling campaign contributions from group members, and donating the money to candidates for political office **($ 5,000 at most** to a candidate for Congress)
  - **Super PACs**: They **do not give money directly** to candidates or parties, but there's no restriction on their expenditures.

How do Interest Groups Exert Influence?

- **Direct lobbying (personal contact with policy makers)**
  - **Grassroots lobbying**: to affect public policy by using citizen contacts or pressure, by letter writing, protest or demonstration
  - **Astroturfing**: "Mimic" grassroots support using paid consulting firms
- **Information campaigns**
  - An organized effort to gain public backing by bringing a group's views to public attention. -> **"public relations"** (Note: Both an art and a science)
- **Coalition building**
  - The banding together of several interest groups for the purpose of lobbying
  - Coalitions often extend beyond organizations with similar constituencies and similar outlooks. (consolidate those who share the same goal)

Next week…

- Read materials on **Mass Media** before class, and that will be helpful to participate in peer discussions.
- Feel free to email me if you have any questions!
- ENJOY YOUR WEEKEND!